

Chapter 1:

Methods

1.1 Method used in analysis

The initial development, simulation and debugging was done using verilator due to its ease of use. Synthesis and implementation were carried out in Vivado. To automate the process of generating implementation reports for multiple point size FFTs, a TCL script was created and vivado was run from terminal with the script, with output to a file. Hardware utilisation, nets, routing summary, timing and power characteristics were obtained using these commands respectively:

```
llength [get_nets -hierarchical]
report_utilization -hierarchical
report_route_status -show_all
report_timing_summary
report_power
```

For estimation of timing, a 10ns clock was assumed:

```
create_clock -period 10.000 -name clk [get_ports clk]
```

And for power utilisation the input switching rate was prescribed, (hence doing a vectorless analysis):

```
set_switching_activity -toggle_rate 2.0 -static_probability 0.95 [get_ports in_valid]
set_switching_activity -toggle_rate 50.0 -static_probability 0.5 [get_ports {din[*]}]
set_switching_activity -toggle_rate 0.0 -static_probability 0.0 [get_ports rst]
```

With this constraints, tool reports medium confidence in power estimation.

The **Artix-7 (part no: xc7a100tcsg324-1)** FPGA was used as reference FPGA on which all synthesis and implementation tasks was done.

1.2 Cooley-Tukey: Radix-2 DIT

Cooley-Tukey algorithm re-expresses the Discrete Fourier Transform (DFT) of an arbitrary composite size $N = N_1 N_2$ in terms of N_1 smaller DFTs of sizes N_2 , recursively, to reduce the computation time to $\mathcal{O}(N \log N)$ for highly composite N . Because of the algorithm's importance, specific variants and implementation styles have become known by their own names, such as Radix-2, Radix-4, mixed-radix, etc. Because the Cooley-Tukey algorithm breaks the DFT into smaller DFTs, it can be combined arbitrarily with any other algorithm for the DFT.

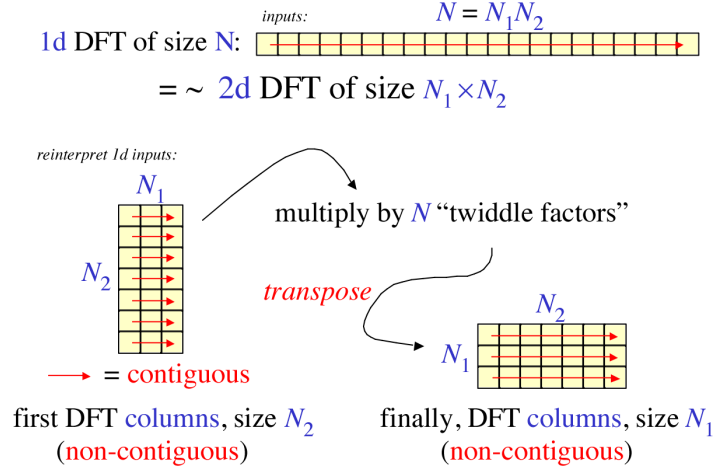


Figure 1.1: Steps involved in Cooley-Tukey algorithm

A radix-2 Decimation in Time (DIT) FFT is the simplest and most common form of the Cooley-Tukey algorithm. Radix-2 DIT divides a DFT of size N into two interleaved DFTs of size $N/2$ with each recursive stage. Hence the overall time complexity of algorithm is $\mathcal{O}(N \log N)$. The following is the derivation of radix-2 DIT:

DFT of sequence x_n is defined by:

$$X_k = \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} x_n \exp\left(-j \frac{2\pi}{N} nk\right)$$

The radix-2 DIT algorithm rearranges the DFT of the function x_n into two parts: a sum over the even-numbered indices $n = 2m$ and a sum over the odd-numbered indices $n = 2m + 1$:

$$\begin{aligned} X_k &= \sum_{m=0}^{N/2-1} x_{2m} \exp\left(-j \frac{2\pi}{N} (2m)k\right) + \sum_{m=0}^{N/2-1} x_{2m+1} \exp\left(-j \frac{2\pi}{N} (2m+1)k\right) \\ &= \underbrace{\sum_{m=0}^{N/2-1} x_{2m} \exp\left(-j \frac{2\pi}{N} mk\right)}_{\text{DFT of even-indexed part of } x_n} + \exp\left(-j \frac{2\pi}{N} k\right) \underbrace{\sum_{m=0}^{N/2-1} x_{2m+1} \exp\left(-j \frac{2\pi}{N} mk\right)}_{\text{DFT of odd-indexed part of } x_n} \\ &= E_k + \exp\left(-j \frac{2\pi}{N} k\right) O_k \end{aligned}$$

Using the periodicity of the complex exponential, $X_{k+\frac{N}{2}}$ is also obtained from E_k and O_k as:

$$X_{k+\frac{N}{2}} = E_k - \exp\left(-j \frac{2\pi}{N} k\right) O_k$$

We can write X_k and $X_{k+\frac{N}{2}}$ as:

$$X_k = E_k + \exp\left(-j\frac{2\pi}{N}k\right)O_k$$

$$X_{k+\frac{N}{2}} = E_k - \exp\left(-j\frac{2\pi}{N}k\right)O_k$$

This result, expressing the DFT of length N recursively in terms of two DFTs of size $N/2$, is the core of the radix-2 DIT FFT. The algorithm gains its speed by re-using the results of intermediate computations to compute multiple DFT outputs. The final outputs are obtained by combination of E_k , O_k and $\exp(-j2\pi k/N)$ (called “twiddle factor” or phase rotation factor) which is simply a size-2 DFT (also called “Butterfly”). The operation can be expressed as a signal flow graph shown in Figure 1.2

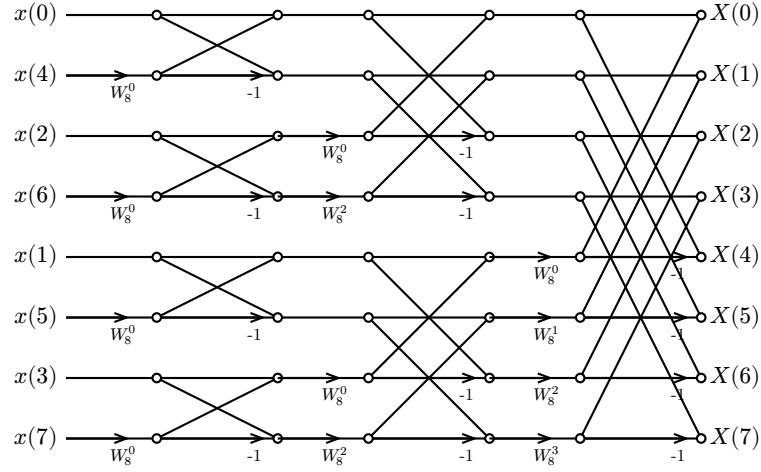


Figure 1.2: Signal flow graph of 8-point radix-2 DIT-FFT

In the software, assuming we have array of input x , the computation begins with reordering the array by swapping element at index i with element at an index which is bit reverse of i . Then subsequently performing radix-2 recursively.

1.2.1 Implementation

The implementation accpets a *fixed point* complex number (given through 2 separate buses for real and imaginary part) and returns computed DFT numbers through another 2 separate buses. This is a burst architecture, hence it waits waits for all inputs to arrive before starting the computation.

The operation described below:

1. A reset pulse is applied
2. Start signal is issued which starts a counter inside the module.
3. `input_valid` signal is applied and input is passed in each positive edge of clock.

Implementation of FFT

4. After N clock cycle, when all input are be given, `input_valid` is reset and module starts computing
5. After $N \log_2(N)/2$ clock cycles the output will be available
6. To read output, output read enable is raised and read address is passed. In the next clock cycle the output will be obtained.

The whole process takes $N + N \log_2(N)/2 + 1$ clock cycles from passing first input to getting first output: N cycles for applying input and getting output and $N \log_2(N)/2 + 1$ cycles for computation.

The design is fully parametric – the number of points and data width can be changed. The twiddle factor is generated using a python script. Design is limited in terms of throughput and latency and is not useful for high performance use cases. In theory area wise this should be most area efficient design, however due to multiple access to the memory, the synthesizer couldnt infer a BRAM, instead it went for flipflops. As a result the design is not scalable to very extend.

The implementation is by no means efficient for practical use, but serves as a base upon which other algorithms can be implemented and evaluated.

About FSM:

When a start signal is sent, the internal counter starts running. Based on the value of counter address to the addresses of relevant data – inputs to butterfly and twiddle factor – is generated by address generator. A portion the counter is bit reversed to produce a address that will be used to store the input. The computing modules and FSM all also run in parallel. The FSM has 4 states:

- IDLE (not doing any processing)
- LOAD (loading input to internal memory)
- COMPUTE (computing the results and storing it in the memory)
- DONE: All computations are done and ready for next cycle.

The operation of FSM is summarized in Figure 1.3.

After the output is ready, it can be read by raising `output_read_en` and passing the address to be read in `output_read_addr`.

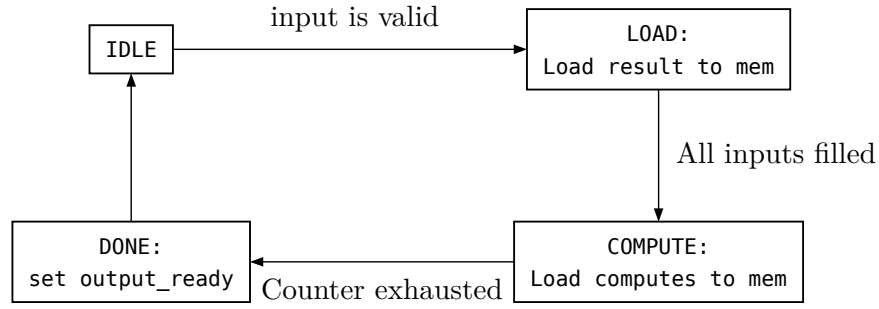


Figure 1.3: Working of FSM in Radix-2 DIT FFT

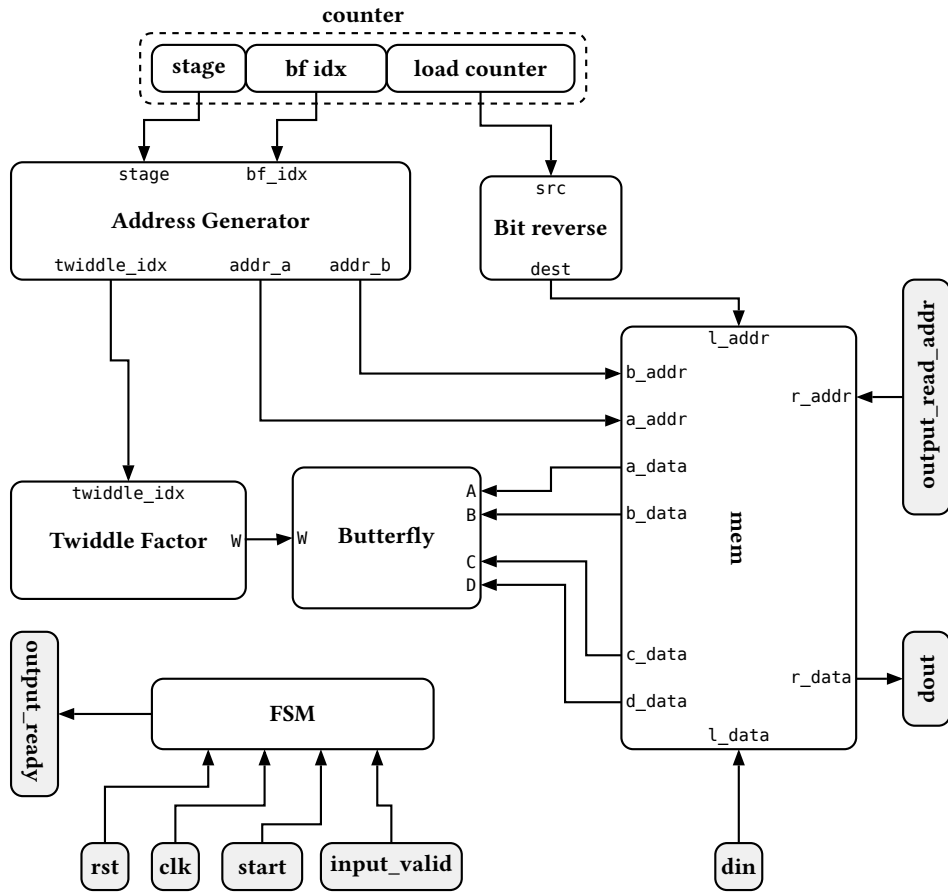


Figure 1.4: Block diagram of Radix-2 DIT FFT implementation

1.2.2 Simulation

Here 4 point DFT is computed in which input is real valued ramp signal. In the Figure 1.5, the output is observed at `dout_re` and `dout_im`. The results were verified using *GNU Octave*. From this we can notice that there is a $N + \frac{N}{2} \log_2(N) + 1$ latency to get first output (one additional clock cycle for shift register at output)

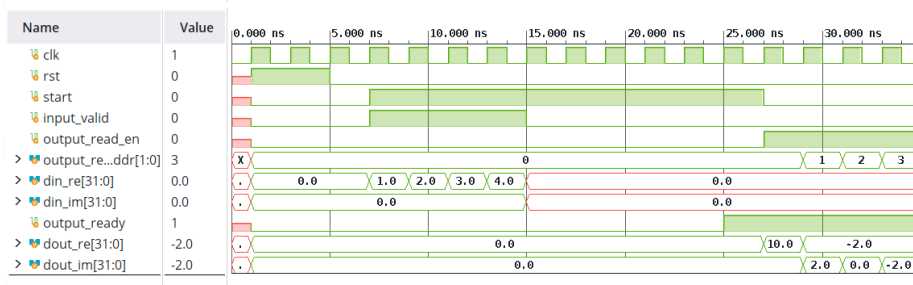


Figure 1.5: Timing diagram of output of 4 point Radix-2 DIT-FFT

1.3 Radix-2 Multi Path Delay Commutator (R2MDC)

This algorithm is based on the Decimation in Frequency (DIF) method. In DIF, the inputs are applied in order, while output obtained will be in bit-reversed form. This allows the input to be fed sequentially. The DIF still gives similar signal flow graph as that of DIT. However the final output has particular pattern that can be used to transform this parallel structure to a pipelined multistaged architecture.

The usual structure of DIF in the case where $N = 4$ is shown in Figure 1.6. Notice that in stage 0, k th and $(k + \frac{N}{2})$ th inputs are required (x_0, x_2 and x_1, x_3). If the data is fed sequentially then one can store first 2 data into a shift register and pop out the value afterwards. This gives the input required for butterfly in the next stage. So the corresponding outputs in each stages are: x'_0, x'_2 and x'_1, x'_3 . But the next stage needs pairs x'_0, x'_1 and x'_2, x'_3 . So twiddle multiplied output of this stage needs to be stored for 1 cycle. Which will satisfy condition for next stage.

In general at stage $s(= 0, 1, \dots, S$ where $S = \lceil \log_2(N) \rceil$ = number of stages) needs shift register of size 2^{S-s} in upper input arm of butterfly and 2^{S-s-1} shift register after the twiddle path. For last stage, multipliers and commutators are not needed. For higher point FFT, design can be scaled easily by cascading more and more R2MDC stages.

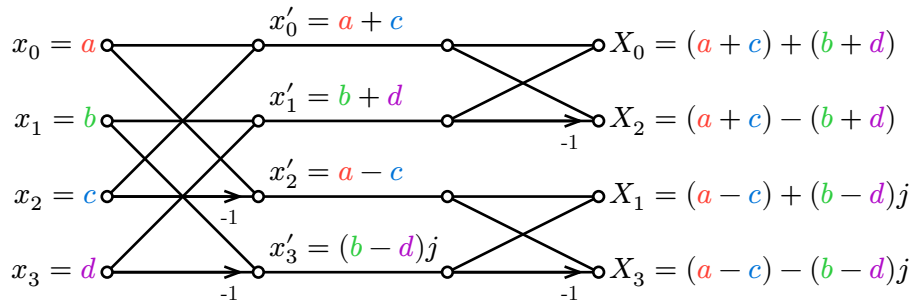


Figure 1.6: Signal flow graph of 4-point radix-2 DIF-FFT

1.3.1 Implementation

The design is fully parametric, in which number of stages, and data width can be changed. The design consists of a controller block that sets the starts the global counter and produces control signals. The outputs **out0** and **out1** are passed to cascade of R2MDC Stage blocks as shown in Figure 1.8. Each R2MDC stage is a pipelined design consisting of a butterfly unit, twiddle ROM and commutator. Butterfly here only computes sum and difference of incoming inputs, the multiplication with twiddle factor is done using a pipelined multiplier. The required twiddle factors are computed during synthesis and are stored in a LUT. The control signals are also delayed by the same amount as that of data lines.

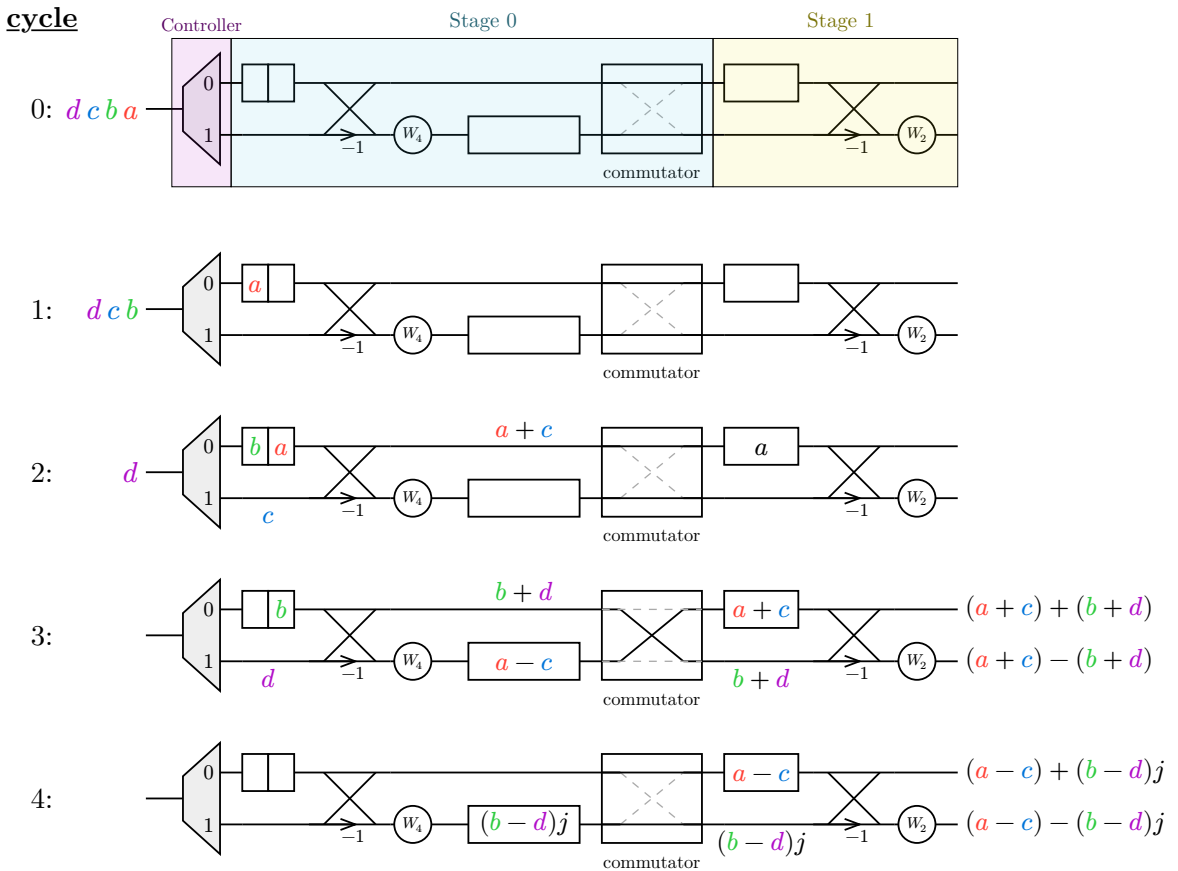


Figure 1.7: Steps in R2MDC algorithm with $N = 4$ case

In each stage the size of delay element reduces by half. No delays, multipliers and commutators are required in final stage. The final output is obtained at **out0** and **out1** corresponding to bit reversed indexed $X[k]$ and $X[k + N/2]$. The control signals **valid** and **counter** are synchronously passed from one stage to another, using delay. As shown in Figure 1.9, two time unit delay is used for pipelining: one for splitting addition and multiplication in butterfly and another one for pipelining complex multiplication in multiplier.

Implementation of FFT

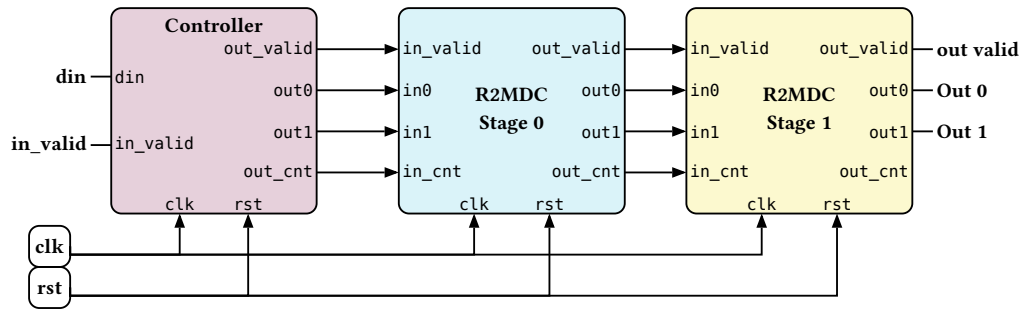


Figure 1.8: Schematic of R2MDC implementation

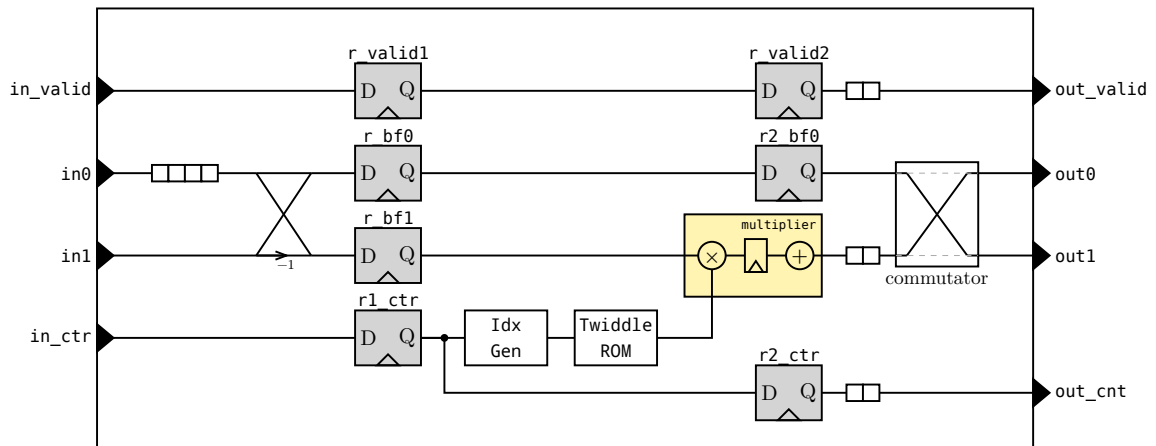


Figure 1.9: Inside a single R2MDC Stage. All modules with wedge is clocked

1.3.2 Simulation result

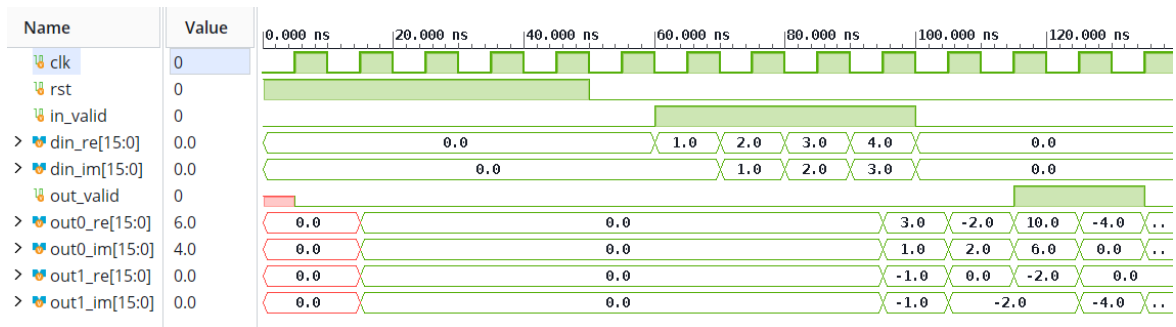


Figure 1.10: Simulation result for 4 point complex test signal

2 outputs are obtained at same clock cycle. Hence it takes $\log_2(N)$ clock cycles to get all outputs after 1st input has been inserted.

1.4 Radix-2 Single Path Delay Commutator (R2SDC)

Single path Delay Commutator is a different pipelined implementation of DIF algorithm. Unlike MDC, SDC produces single output per cycle and uses fewer number of shift registers, at the expense of higher latency and higher complexity of stage controllers. The whole operation is described in Figure 1.13. A overview is given below:

1. In first $N/2$ clock cycles data coming is shifted to shift registers
2. In coming cycles, $x[n]$ and $x[n + N/2]$ datas are available. The butterfly computes the sum and difference, in which the difference is shifted back to the same shift register and sum is passed to twiddle factor multiplier.
3. After all inputs are passed (cycles $> N$) the shift register is completely full of differences. It shifts it out to twiddle factor directly.

1.4.1 Implementation

The design is similar to that of MDC, with the difference that each stage now has its own counter that creates control signal for that stage.

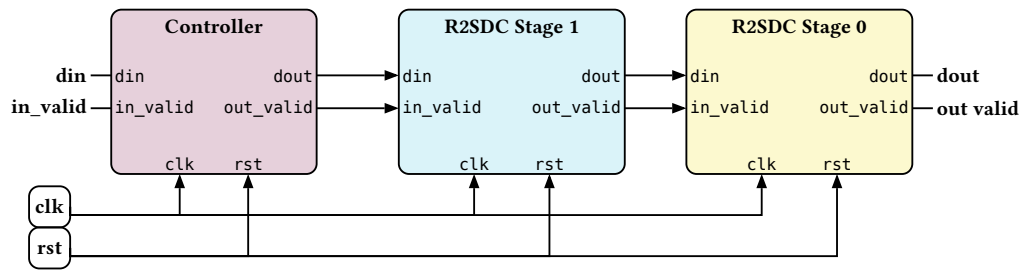


Figure 1.11: Schematic of R2SDC implementation

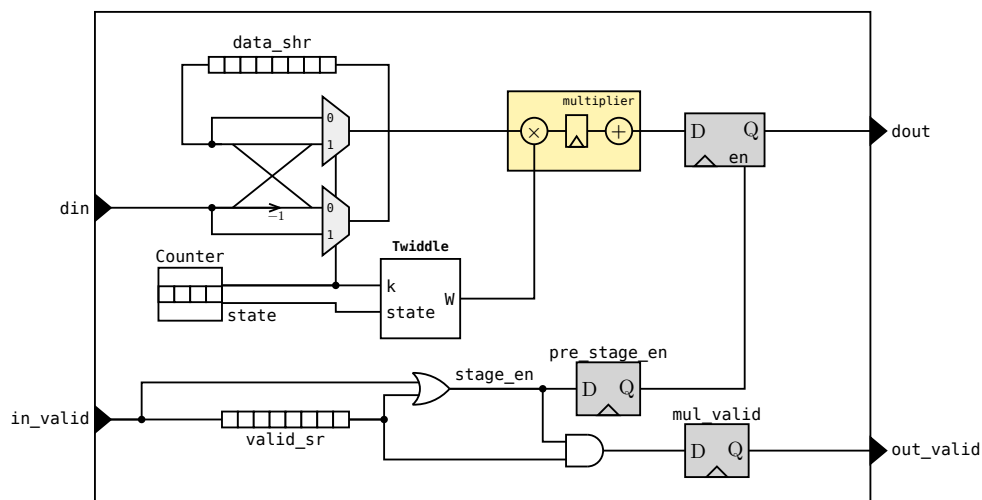


Figure 1.12: Inside a single R2SDC Stage. All modules with wedge is clocked

Implementation of FFT

From this point onwards, the twiddle factors are computed using **initial** blocks, which is expected to be synthesized to a LUT.

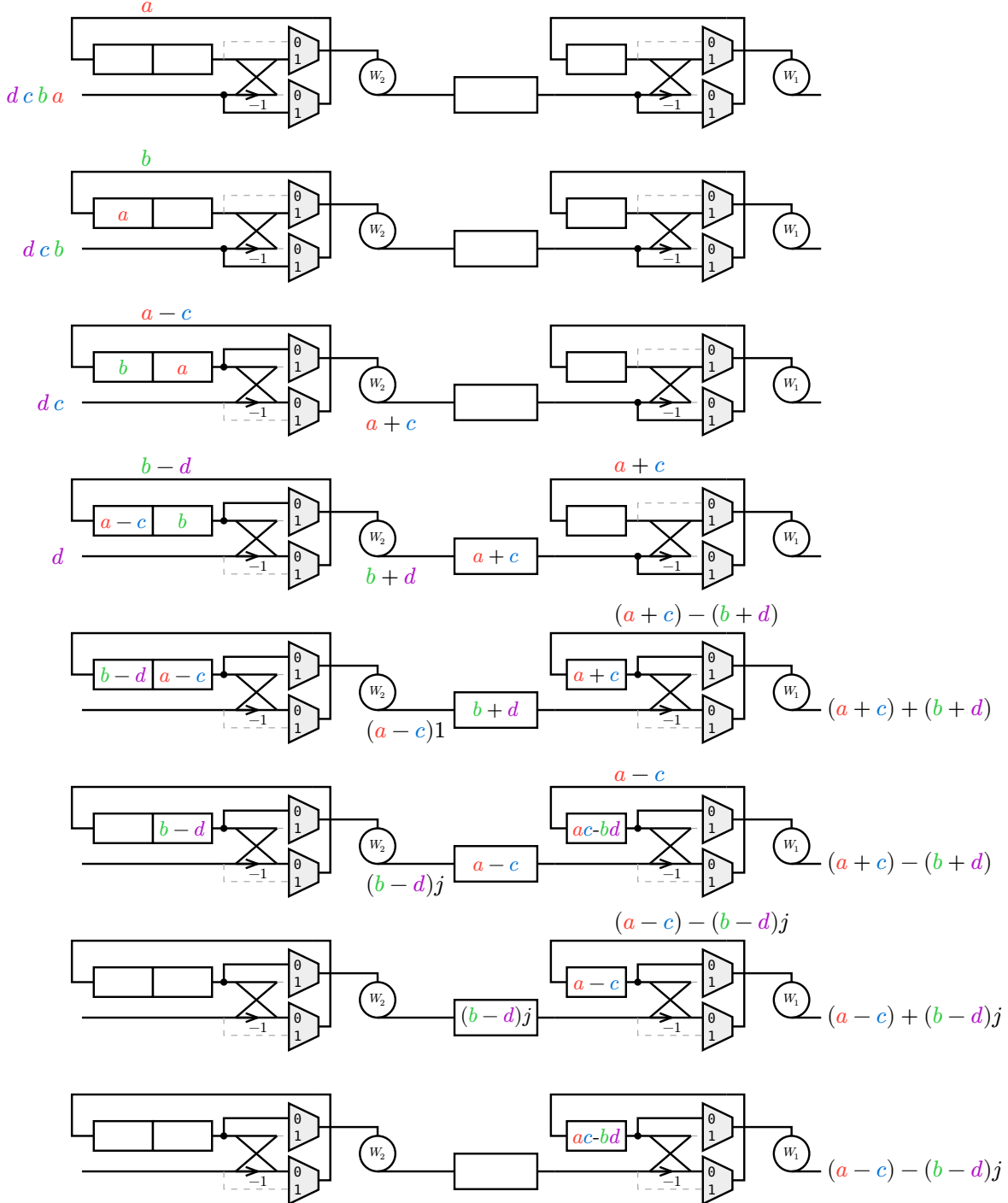


Figure 1.13: Steps involved in a 4 point R2SDC algorithm

1.4.2 Simulation result

The result is similar to that of MDC case. But here due slightly different architecture, the output arrives one clock cycle earlier.

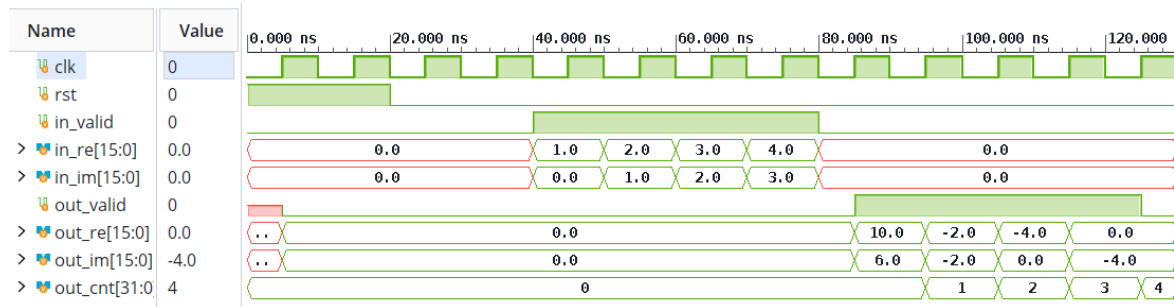
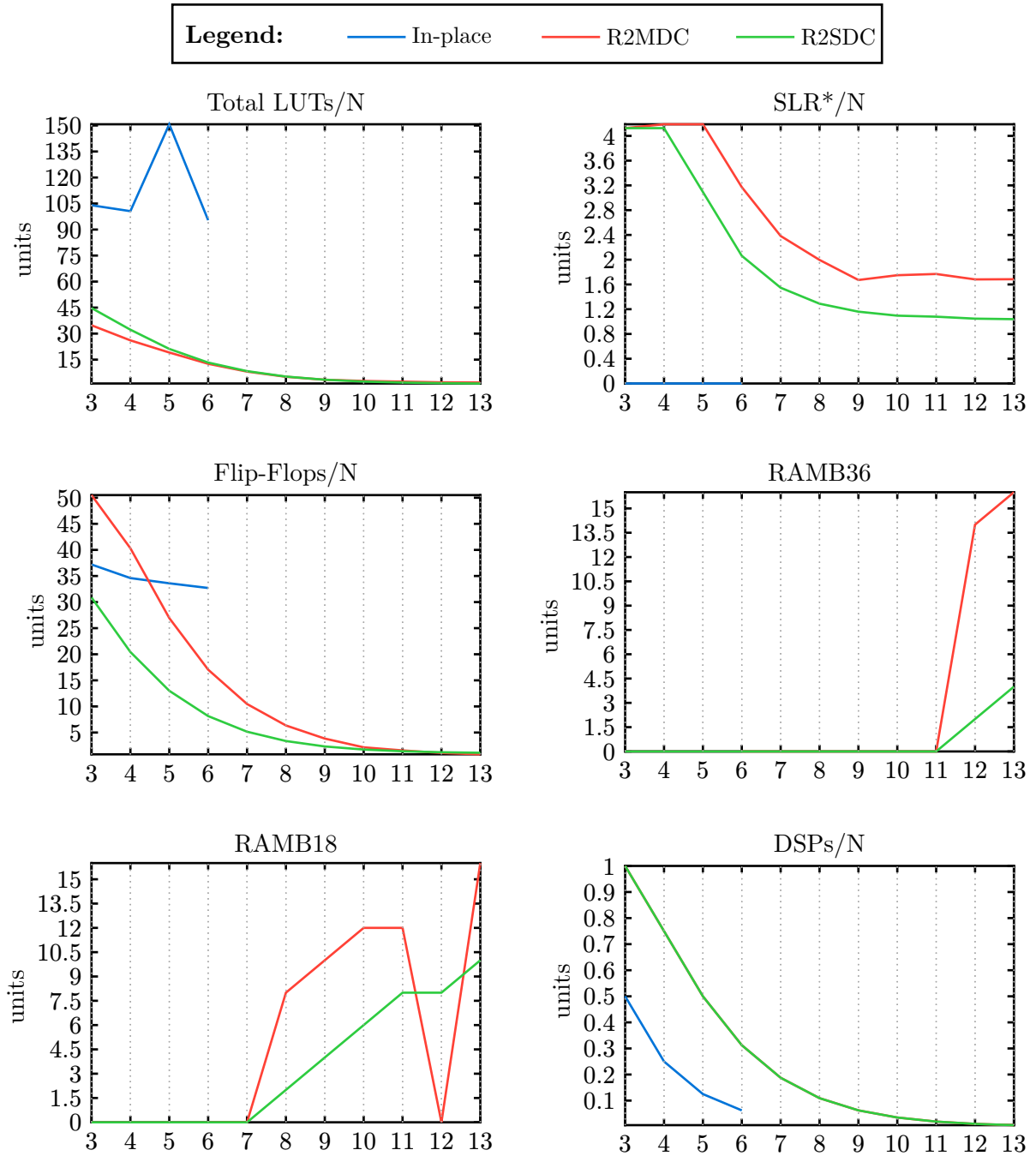


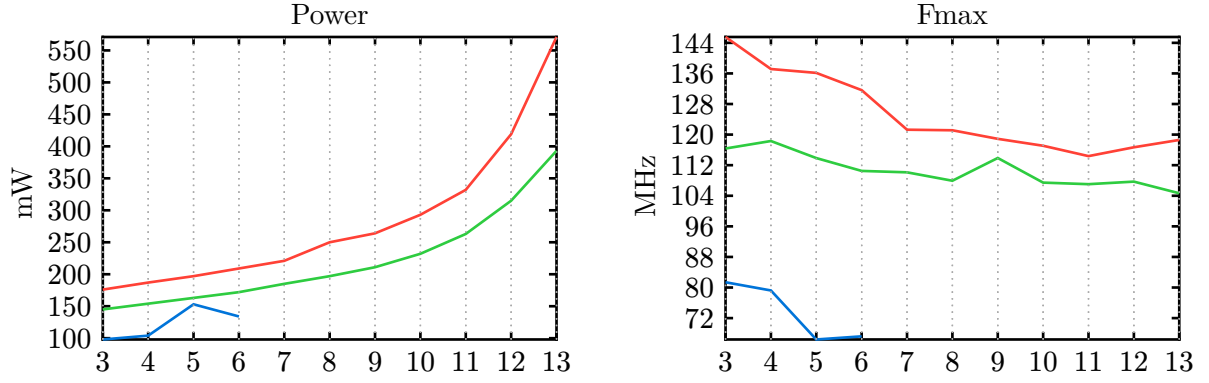
Figure 1.14: Simulation result for 4 point complex test signal

1.5 Winograd

Chapter 2: Comparison

All datas have been plotted here for quick comparison:





SLR: Super Logic Region

The throughput trend closely matches with $F_{\max}$. From this we its clear that inplace algorithm performs worse in all cases except at power consumption. Also MDC architecture is preferred in high throughput requirements (such as radar, SDR, etc.). With both pipelined architectures, the synthesis tool was able to infer BRAM blocks past a certain number of transform size.